



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

HANNIBAL ALI shops at Süprmarkt, an organic grocery store on Slauson Avenue in South Los Angeles.

Feeding bodies, spirits in South L.A.

A health food oasis grows in an area neglected by big grocery chains.

By TYRONE BEASON

Olympia Auset's route to opening a health food emporium in one of the food deserts of Los Angeles started with her own trips to the grocery store.

It was 16 years ago. Auset was fresh out of college and living on a vegan diet. Her neighborhood largely lacked healthful options, and she wound up commuting two hours round-trip by bus to buy nutritious food that fit her budget as a recipient of federal food aid.

"You spend all of this time on the bus, get somewhere that has healthy food and then you're having to debate with yourself: Can I afford this apple?" Auset recalled.

From those demoralizing trips across town, Auset went on to found Süprmarkt, a nonprofit organic produce business on Slauson Avenue in South L.A. that started as a street pop-up in 2016 and grew into a storefront grocery in 2024 thanks in large part to a community crowdfunding campaign.

The inequity in access to healthful food spans the whole county but hurts its poorest residents and communities of color the most, researchers at USC found in a study last year.

About 25% of Los Angeles County residents don't consistently know they'll have enough food, and even more, 29%, lack access to nutritious foods that can help [See **Market**, A7]

San Bernardino shots still echo a decade later

Terror attack took 14 lives, changed many more and shaped politics and policing

By Jack Dolan, Hailey Branson-Potts and Richard Winton

Mandy Pifer, a therapist, was with a client in Los Angeles on Dec. 2, 2015, when she received a text about a mass shooting in San Bernardino. Her fiancé, Shannon Johnson, was a restaurant inspector there.

She didn't panic until, driving home, she heard on the radio that the victims were employees of the Inland Empire city's environmental health department. She grabbed her phone and dialed Shannon's number over and over, but it kept going straight to voicemail. That's when she knew, "in my bones," he was gone.

She was right. That morning the man she loved and planned to marry used his body to shield a 27-year-old co-worker in what would become the deadliest terrorist attack on U.S. soil since 9/11. His last words, as he held his terrified colleague close, were, "I got you."

Johnson's death "changed the whole trajectory of my life," Pifer said through tears in a recent interview. "Everything now is before or after 'the event.'"

Tuesday marks the 10th year since

restaurant inspector Syed Rizwan Farook, a U.S. citizen, and his Pakistan-born wife, Tashfeen Malik, walked into his office holiday party with military-style assault rifles and shot more than 30 people, killing 14.

The unspeakable violence, apparently inspired by jihadist propaganda online, thrust the often-overlooked and financially bankrupt city of San Bernardino into the global spotlight.

The U.S. has suffered deadlier shootings since San Bernardino — including the 2016 massacre at Pulse, an LGBTQ+ nightclub in Orlando, Fla., in which another American inspired by online terrorist propaganda killed 49 — but the attack in San Bernardino had the most sweeping impact on American politics and ushered in the nation's current era of divisive immigration enforcement.

Less than a week after the killings, then-presidential candidate Donald Trump used the tragedy to call for "a total and complete shutdown of Muslims entering the United States."

[See **Shooting**, A14]

Fire agencies face scrutiny over failure to stop rekindled blazes

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

Firefighters knew the charred skeleton of a tractor still was smoking when they left the valley floor in Ventura County last year, but didn't think it posed any danger.

A week after crews declared the 1.8-acre Balcom fire out, powerful Santa Ana winds arrived, picked up some bits of hot rubber from one of the tractor's scorched tires and carried them over into dry vegetation, bringing

the fire back to life, according to investigators.

Though Ventura County Fire Department officials said they went by the book when they left the Balcom fire — clearing containment lines, dropping retardant and even using a drone with an infrared camera to identify lingering heat — it wasn't enough. The Mountain fire burned nearly 20,000 acres and destroyed roughly 250 homes and structures in Camarillo Hills and nearby communities in western Ventura County.

As climate change makes

the drying landscape more vulnerable, the Mountain and Palisades fires, both originating from smaller blazes firefighters thought they had put out, are raising questions about whether agencies need to rethink how they ensure fires truly are extinguished.

Many agencies have utilized technology such as infrared drones to scan for lingering heat, but the solution might be as simple as spending extra time patrolling after the fire to ensure nothing is smoldering, experts say.

[See **Rekindled**, A5]

Targeting of Venezuela is raising alarm

New revelations emerge about Trump team's tactics for escalating the conflict.

By MICHAEL WILNER, ANA CEBALLOS, KATE LINTHICUM AND PATRICK J. McDONNELL

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is facing sharp scrutiny this week over its approach to Venezuela after turning its focus to the beleaguered nation, weighing U.S. military strikes against a Latin American state for the first time in more than 35 years.

President Trump scheduled a meeting with top generals and Cabinet officials on the matter at the White House on Monday evening, debating target options now available with the deployment of more than a dozen warships to the Caribbean Sea.

Trump has sent conflicting signals to the country's dictatorial president, Nicolás Maduro, whose grip on power since 2013 has decimated Venezuela's economy and prompted a massive migration crisis. Trump

warned air traffic away from Venezuelan skies before speaking by phone with Maduro over the weekend, only to caution reporters trying to interpret his actions against predicting his next moves.

Whether Trump will choose to go to war with Venezuela has become a source of alarm on Capitol Hill as new revelations emerge about his team's tactics for escalating the conflict.

The White House has accused Maduro of driving migrants and drugs across America's borders, and has begun pressuring his government with military strikes targeting maritime vessels — in international waters, but departing from Venezuela — that the Defense Department claims have been used to smuggle illegal narcotics.

The first of those attacks targeting alleged drug traffickers, conducted on Sept. 2, included a second strike ordered by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth to "kill them all," according to a report by the Washington Post.

The Post report has prompted the Republican-led House and Senate com- [See **Venezuela**, A7]

Migrants detained despite court wins

Attorneys observe an escalating trend of the government holding people indefinitely.

By ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — R.V. already had spent six months detained at a facility in California when he won his case in immigration court in June.

He testified that he had fled his native Cuba last year after protesting against the government, for which he was jailed, surveilled and persecuted. So, after being kidnapped in Mexico, he entered the U.S. illegally and told border agents he was afraid of his life.

An immigration court judge granted him protection against deportation to Cuba, and R.V., 21, was looking forward to reuniting with family in Florida.

But R.V., who asked that his full name not be used for

fear of retaliation from the government, hasn't been released. At the detention center, he said, agents have told him they'll still find a way to deport him — if not to Cuba, then maybe Panama or Costa Rica.

"The wait is so hard," he said in an interview. "It's as if they don't want to accept that I won."

R.V. is among what immigration attorneys describe as an escalating trend: Some immigrants who win protection from deportation to their home countries are being detained indefinitely.

Often, the person has been held while the federal government appealed their win or sought another country willing to accept them.

The government has long had the ability to make such appeals or to seek another country where it could deport someone; the Department of Homeland Security generally has 90 days to find somewhere else to send them.

[See **Detained**, A6]

Should California get its first gas pipeline?

Touted as 'huge' for consumers, proposal is also seen as a step back

By HAYLEY SMITH

California has long been a "fuel island" — a state whose gasoline and diesel markets are isolated from the rest of the country — but that could soon end under a proposed plan to build the first pipeline to bring refined products directly to the West Coast.

Known as the Western Gateway Pipeline, the project from oil major Phillips 66 and global pipeline giant Kinder Morgan would deliver gasoline, diesel and jet fuel to Arizona and California from as far east as Mis-



RICK LOOMIS Los Angeles Times

AS THE Wilmington refinery nears its closure, the pipeline from the Midwest is pitched as a new lifeline.

souri by 2029. The companies are currently scoping out demand and seeking commitments from customers in what is known as an "open season."

Kinder Morgan is already a major pipeline operator in California. Officials from both companies say the pipeline would create a vital connection between the Midwest and California, where a combination of unique fuel requirements and geography have created a market that is almost entirely dependent on fuel brought in by ship plus in-state supplies. That can [See **Pipeline**, A10]



PAUL KURODA For The Times

HORROR IN STOCKTON

Family members return to a banquet hall that held a toddler's birthday party and then was the scene of a deadly mass shooting. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

UCLA expected to hire Chesney

Bruins tap promising James Madison coach to turn around their struggling football program. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 68/53. **B6**

Markets **A11**
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Indian truckers idle at holidays

Many have lost their licenses amid extra scrutiny after horrific accident. **BUSINESS, A9**

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